Science Fiction

The Birth of Cyberspace

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The term “cyberspace” was first created as a shared mental space, changing how people viewed the internet (Gibson, 1984).

Gibson (1984) called cyberspace a “consensual hallucination,” a shared data space made of “lines of light” and “clusters… like city lights” .

Gibson (1984) was the first to imagine “cyberspace” as a mental digital world, shaping how people later viewed the internet as a shared space.

Consensual Hallucination

Science Fiction Came First

Body

Cyberspace makes the body feel split: the user is “plugged in,” facing mental and physical strain, yet also experiencing new sensory extensions of data and light (Gibson, 1984).

Self

People shape identities and control how they appear online. Nakamura (1995) notes this freedom is mixed with limits about who gets to be seen.

What it feels like inside

Space

Gibson (1984) pictured cyberspace as “city lights” and grids, while Fernback (1997) called it a new public arena and frontier for creating and relating.



Imaginaries of Cyberspace

Streeter (2011) links internet imaginaries to romantic ideas of freedom, treating the net as more than technology.

Freedom

Cultural Frames

Connection

Streeter (2011) highlights “connection” as central: linking people to each other, to nature, and to the wider world.

How Science Fiction Shapes Culture



Media

Akira (1988)

Gave an early image of machines and social order.

Tron (1982)

Pictured people entering the computer, shaping visions of virtual worlds.

Metropolis (1927)

Showed links between technology, the body, and society.

Cyberspace

Terms & Metaphors

Hallucination

Gibson (1984) created the word, and it became a key term in how people imagine the internet.

“Consensual hallucination” is a metaphor for the immersive experience of cyberspace.

Frontier/Arena

Fernback (1997) described cyberspace as a “new arena” or “frontier” for human activity.

How it changed our world

Models

Films like Metropolis (1927), Tron (1982) gave early models for virtual worlds. These works shaped how people imagined cyberspace (Week 2 lecture slides, 2025).

Culture

Science fiction helped people see the internet as part of culture, not just technology. This view still shapes digital platforms today, as ideas from science fiction stories influence how spaces like the metaverse are built and understood (Week 2 lecture slides, 2025).

Futures

Science fiction imaginaries as both utopian and dystopian, using works like Neuromancer and The Matrix to illustrate freedom, control, and risk in digital futures (Week 2 lecture slides, 2025).

Utopian & Dystopian Futures

Utopian

Freedom

In Neuromancer, Case prefers cyberspace over his body, showing it as a space of escape and freedom. Science fiction often imagines the net as breaking physical limits (Gibson, 1984).

Community

Fernback (1997) calls cyberspace a “new arena for participation in public life.” Sci-fi visions picture it as a place where individuals connect and form collective life (p. 37).

Frontier

Cyberspace is compared to the American frontier, offering exploration and creation. In this utopian view, people can build, live, and relate in new digital spaces (Fernback, 1997).

Dystopian

Surveillance



Dystopian sci-fi warns that the net can be used for watching and control. In The Matrix (1999), cyberspace is a system driven by data and rules, showing users as monitored but also able to break free (Week 2 lecture slides, 2025).

Danger

In Neuromancer, cyberspace is risky, hackers can suffer real harm even if danger begins online. The lecture also shows that being “plugged in” carries physical and mental costs (Gibson, 1984; Week 2 lecture slides, 2025).

Control

In Neuromancer, cyberspace feels free but is also ruled by big systems and companies. The lecture shows dystopian visions where power online can limit people instead of giving freedom (Gibson, 1984; Week 2 lecture slides, 2025).



Reference

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